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The Paradox of Omnipotence: Doctor Manhattan and the Ontology of Powerlessness

The paradox of omnipotence lies in the contradiction of: if an omnipotent being can create a stone so heavy they cannot lift it, they cease to be omnipotent. But if they cannot create such a stone, their power is already limited. In *Watchmen*, Dr. Manhattan embodies this very paradox. He possesses nearly unlimited power, he is able to alter matter, perceive the future, and transcend the temporal-spatial constraints of human being, but on the deepest level, he cannot truly make a choice, nor can he change the future he already knows. His omniscience traps him in fatalism and renders him powerless. People call him omnipotent, but what I see is a being utterly powerless. He is neither truly human nor fully divine. He is a being of pure rationality, it seems he has no choice but to act in accordance with that rationality. He continually repeats the calculations of logic, but the possibility of free will has been lost. In this paper, I will take the *paradox of omnipotence* as my theoretical foundation and, by examining Dr. Manhattan's concrete actions and dialogues in *Watchmen*, explore what "omnipotence" really means: does it truly imply freedom, or is Dr. Manhattan in fact a figure through whom we can see the collapse of the distinction between omnipotence and impotence. A state of extreme detachment and paralysis, in which total power and total absence are ultimately the same void.

We begin by examining Dr. Manhattan's struggle with love, and how it reveals the conflict between free will and determinism. Laurie repeatedly questions him about his indifference, about why he left Earth, and he calmly replies that the future is already written, that emotion is meaningless. "A live body and a dead body contain the same number of particles. Structurally, there's no discernible difference." His absolute rationality, his omniscient perspective, dissolves all value judgments, including emotional ones. Dr. Manhattan knows Laurie will leave him, that she will fall in love with Dan, so in the present he is not able to invest emotionally, nor does he want to engage. He knows the future, and thus can not truly live in the present. The question is, if one already knows that a relationship will end, can they still freely love? To be human is to exist within a world that is not yet determined. Dr. Manhattan has been deprived of this condition. If we draw on *Laplacean determinism*, we could say that once one is omniscient, action becomes impossible. In his relationship with Laurie, Dr. Manhattan is not choosing his behavior, but re-enacting a known script. "We are all puppets, Laurie. I'm just a puppet who can see the strings." That's exactly the core of this theory, that omniscience doesn't give him the power to do anything he wants, it's not a freedom, but instead a chain, it is a psychological fatalism. And what's worse, this sense of paralysis is utterly misunderstood by those around him. This is the ultimate punishment, to appear omnipotent, but be fundamentally helpless.

The philosopher Heidegger, in *Being and Time*, repeatedly emphasizes that human existence is not defined by what one is, but by what one has not yet become. To exist means to be constantly deciding oneself through time. Love, in particular, is a strong example of this, for it is a commitment to the Other (a philosophical term,) to a commitment that can only exist in an open, undetermined future. If we apply this to Dr. Manhattan, once this openness and incompleteness, the core of human value is stripped away, what is left of him? His failure to be godlike is not due to imperfection or lack of ability, but precisely because he was once human. He once had feelings, once experienced limits, once desired. He once loved Laurie like a normal man with longing and hope. It is this flawed part of him that prevents him from being a true god. He can understand humanity, but he is no

longer part of it. This problem is also clearly reflected in his experience during the Vietnam War.

There is a scene in which Dr. Manhattan, with a wave of his hand, vaporizes soldiers in Vietnam. Those around him feel a calmness deeper than fear, his detachment is not born of coldness, but from mechanical neutrality. It's not that he doesn't care, it's that the very category of caring doesn't exist for him. His actions are neither driven by hatred nor anger, to him, these acts are not morally right or wrong, because morality itself is negligible. War, in his eyes involves no passion and no ethical hesitation, everything is simply unfolding according to a script. He is the reader and at the same time a part of the casts acting on stage, playing his role. This brings us to the question on nature of ethics. As Levinas believes, ethics is not generally viewed as abstract, but as the experience of being called when I see the face of the Other. But for Dr. Manhattan, he can barely see faces, he sees particle structures and predictive paths. That's why even if he understands others on an intellectual surface, he does not have the ability to truly respond to their suffering. The most terrifying thing about Dr. Manhattan is not his inhuman coldness, but his anti-ethical condition, that is for him, even the possibility of "wrong" does not exist. He is not saddened by the past, nor anxious about the future. He is a witness to everything, but a participant in nothing. He is not a bearer of responsibility. If, in the realm of love, he has lost the capacity to invest in the future, then in war, he demonstrates how ethics, once built upon omnipotence can completely collapse. In his universe, perhaps no one deserves saving. No one truly dies. Every life is merely particles, endlessly rearranged. Nothing could be more ordinary.

Dr. Manhattan's omniscience renders him unable to practice morality, he witnesses suffering but is powerless to intervene. However, not everyone in *Watchmen* is paralyzed by knowledge. Adrian Veidt chooses to act, and does so radically. What his actions reveal however, is another form of impotence, it is the collapse of morality under the illusion of absolute meaning. Dr. Manhattan does nothing because everything is predetermined, Veidt

would do anything because nothing matters. This is because Veidt operates according to a cold utilitarian logic, he chooses to sacrifice the few for the survival of the many, and even believes he possesses the right to make life-and-death decisions on behalf of all humanity. This supposedly rational concern for the greater good does not constitute meaningful ethical action. Instead, it becomes a form of nihilism disguised as reason. Within this logic, action is no longer a response to moral responsibility but a matter of control and narrative manipulation, the peace he creates is nothing more than a meticulously staged illusion. Veidt and Dr. Manhattan thus form a kind of mirror image. The former refrains from action because he knows too much, he knows, therefore he does not act. The latter acts because he believes in nothing, he does not believe, therefore he acts without restraint.

Dr. Manhattan's inaction arises from metaphysical nihilism, his belief is that everything is predetermined and that choice is but an illusion. Veidt's postmodern nihilism is more radical, to him, the death of truth and the absence of any ethical center mean that action is stripped of all real meaning. His decisions are purely strategic, devoid of any appeal to responsibility. As a result, he manufactures a kind of peace, but one that is essentially false. It is an imposed order, an immune to questioning, he plays the role of a god, imitates the divine perspective, and claims to possess ultimate truth and foresight. But is this truly omnipotence or merely a delusion born of an extreme will to control? Veidt is not all-powerful, from what I see, he is simply brilliant enough to believe he could become a god. His supposed omnipotence is a myth of his own making, and it reveals itself to be a form of impotence, a selective impotence constructed to justify his violence and hubris. Dr. Manhattan's impotence is ontological, it stems from the existential paralysis that accompanies true omniscience. Having transcended human temporality, he can no longer act as a human being. Veidt, on the other hand, remains human but attempts to become divine. Both ultimately expose the same paradox: when a person is imagined as omnipotent, he becomes incapable of true action. This is the central philosophical contradiction explored in this paper. Veidt's actions appear effective, but they lack any moral foundation. Dr. Manhattan's silence appears useless, but it points to an inescapable existential impasse.

Both characters embody the image of omnipotence, but in *Watchmen*, omnipotence is never a source of freedom, rather, it is a condition of extreme powerlessness. True omnipotence cannot exist without canceling itself out, in the world of *Watchmen*, to be all-powerful is paradoxically, to be unable to act.

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